



ideas, the same aspirations, the same background. The reaction to too much diversity, in other words, is that people organise themselves into miniature versions of Finland.

This, then, is one of the surprising effects of diversity—rather than pulling people apart, it induces them to clot together. The phenomenon is observed in various other contexts globally—witness the way so many first generation immigrants in the West retract into the most orthodox religious groups they can find, to distance themselves from the alien culture around. In India, this clotting process repeats itself at higher levels. The groups that people form, regarded now as individual entities, still find themselves awash in a sea of tremendous diversity. The same mechanism as before will now cause these groups to

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ONE GOAL: Groups act in their own interest

clump together in reaction—moreover, this process plays out again at still higher levels, to give a fractal hierarchy. For instance, local communities of leatherworkers might imbed themselves in a larger regional community of the same profession, which in turn might bond with other regional Dalit groups to remain afloat in the surrounding sea of non-Dalit groups.

Let me make a few points about the above model. At each stage, the primary role diversity plays is not necessarily to give birth to new conglomerations, but to provide the pressure that keeps them stable, no matter how they originated. An advantage of the model is that it helps explain why such an elaborate hierarchical structure of sub-castes and castes continues to endure in India. It should be noted that significant overlap can exist between various groups and conglomerations—for instance, while an individual's primary identification might be with a professional, familial, or caste-based group, he might also feel a sense of allegiance to larger conglomerations structured around factors like language or religion.

While individuals or their immediate low-level groups have very limited power, rising through

the hierarchy, we eventually reach conglomerations large enough to have political clout (for example, the group of all Dalits, of all Muslims, of Gujaratis, of Punjabis, etc.). How does “Unity in Diversity” apply at this level? Is the Wikipedia explanation finally sufficient? Does the size of these groups make them more sensitive, more responsible, ready to stifle their own needs and desires for the greater good of the country?

The answer is that groups, like individuals, also tend to act in their own self-interest, rather than out of nobility or altruism. If the membership of these large groups was economically stultified, and there were clear advantages to secession, then we would see vigorous campaigns for it played out all over the nation. But the fact is that people's lives in India have been

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improving—slowly, it is true, but steadily—as most indicators (poverty, rate of literacy, the UN's human development index) from the past three decades show. In addition, the boom of the last several years has infused sections of the population with a new optimism about the future, even if it might not yet be in their grasp. There does not seem to be a glaring economic imperative, either now or in the recent past, for a group to give up on India and strike out on its own.

When such secessionist ideas do arise, however, diversity plays an important role in damping them out. Recall how the top-level conglomerations arose in our model—through the combination of “building block” groups at lower levels. As we ascend this hierarchy of groups from the smallest to the largest, we can expect an increasing amount of variation in background, class, culture, religion. The fact that most individuals end up belonging to several different conglomerations contributes to this variation. The groups at the top, the ones large enough to effect political change, are the least homogeneous—consequently, they will generally have constituents with divergent aims and interests. Uniting all these constituents behind any action, particularly one geared towards radical change,

